

Can you believe it? Winter is in full swing, the trees and landscape are dead, the weather leaves much to be desired, the year 2000 has come to a conclusion, and 2001 is about to begin. Even though most of us do not like winter, we patiently endure it because we know spring is just around the corner, and with spring there will be **“A NEW BEGINNING”**. The year 2001 is the beginning of the twenty first century. It is my opinion that as a church we should look upon this year as **“A NEW BEGINNING”**.

God's word is full of examples of people who were afforded the opportunity for **“A NEW BEGINNING”**. After more than 400 years of slavery in Egypt, Israel was given a new lease on life in the form of **“A NEW BEGINNING”**. **Exodus 12:1-2** ***“And the Lord spake unto Moses and Aaron in the land of Egypt, saying, This month shall be unto you the beginning of months: it shall be the first month of the year to you.”***

In order to bring this **“NEW BEGINNING”** about for the Israelites, God sets a bush on fire in the desert and speaks to a senior citizen by the name of Moses to lead them from Egypt to Caanan. For Israel the visitation of the death angel meant the **“BEGINNING”** of a new epoch, a new era, this would be a new starting point. God is no respecter of persons, what he did for Israel, he will do for you and I! **Isaiah 43:19** ***“Behold, I will do a new thing; now it shall spring forth; shall ye not know it? I will even make a way in the wilderness, and rivers in the desert.”***

If you were to research the history of Israel, you would find a path strewn with the wreckage of centuries of exile and servitude. For Israel this **“NEW BEGINNING”** was to be an emancipation, a redemption, an exodus! I'm quite sure that many of the Israelites wondered if they would ever be able to completely shake the monkey of enslavement and servitude, and experience **“A NEW BEGINNING”**. The answer to that question is that God would provide the grace and tools necessary for them to live free from the past, but the real test would be whether they would do what was necessary to facilitate this **“NEW BEGINNING”**.

God desires the same for us! He wants to wipe the slate clean, forgive the past, and make bright the future! The real question is, can you forget the past and by faith lay hold of the future? As with Israel, repentance and forgiveness are the foundational stones upon which **“A NEW BEGINNING”** is built. To repent means to say you are sorry for the wrong you have done, and make a firm commitment never to repeat the action. To forgive is to allow God by the power of his Holy Spirit to take the pain out of a past experience, to the point that you have no desire to even the score. If you truly desire to have **“A NEW BEGINNING”** you must firmly plant your spiritual feet upon these two foundational stones.

Responsibility comes with **“A NEW BEGINNING”**. When Israel left Egypt they were confronted with the hardships of the wilderness, and finally with the responsibility of driving the giants out of Caanan. There comes a time for those who have experienced **“A NEW BEGINNING”** to be schooled and disciplined by processes that are less than

desireable. It is in these difficult times that the characteristics of our Heavenly Father are developed within us. These processes cannot be hurried, rather patiently and faithfully endured. I believe that the year of 2000, as difficult as it was, has set the stage for God to do a new thing within this church. I can hardly wait to see what God is going to accomplish in 2001 as we prepare for **“A NEW BEGINNING”!**